

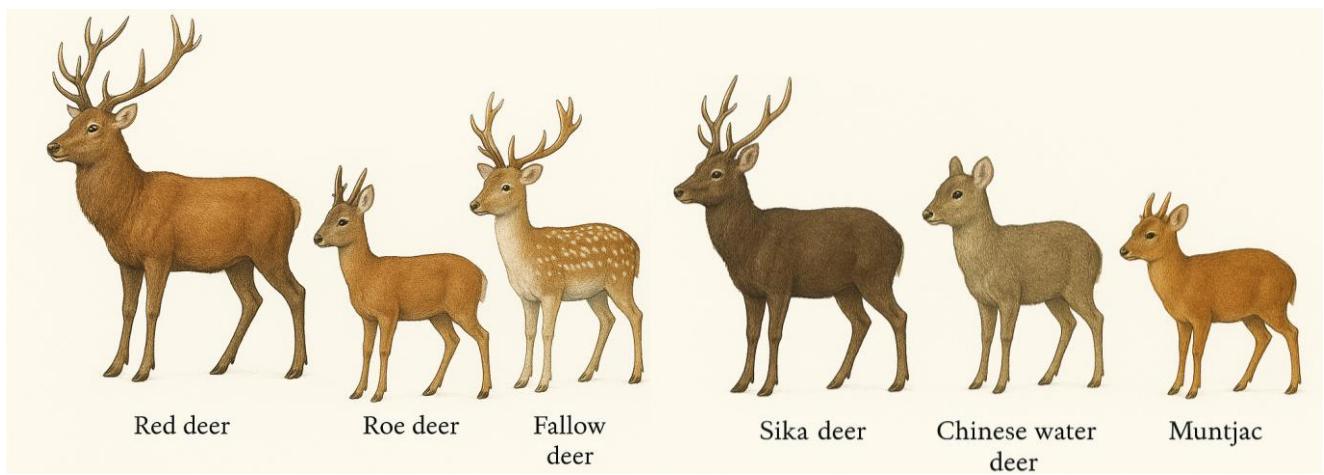
South Downs Venison Information Pack

Introduction

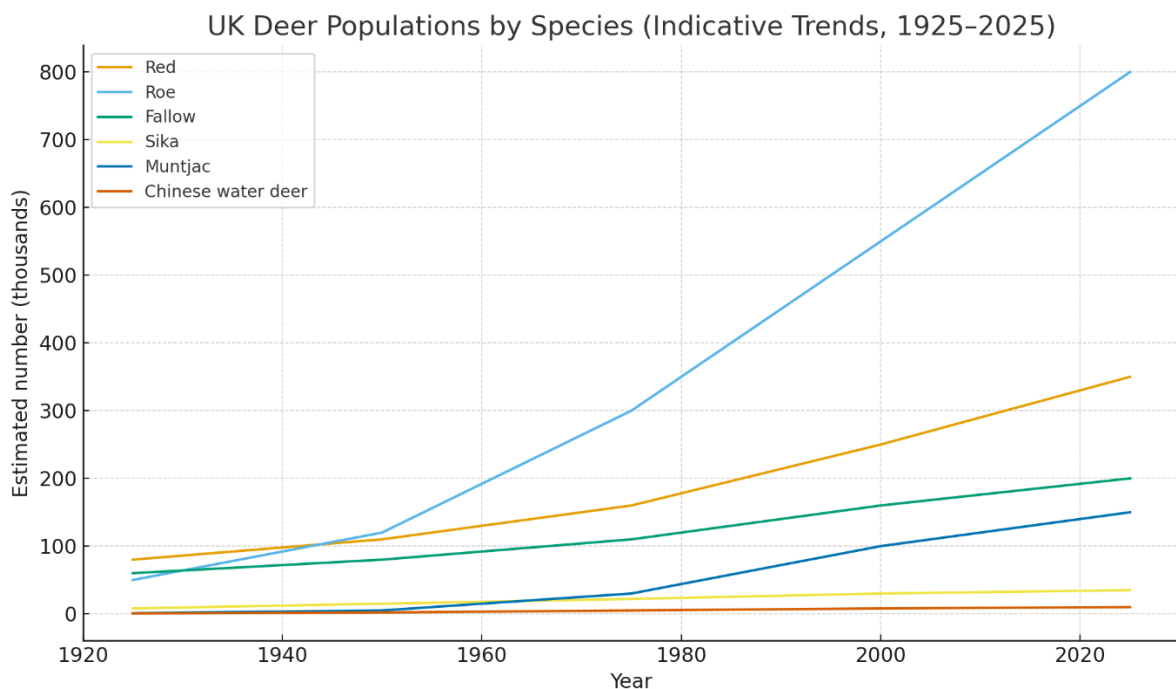
Chef's Farms has partnered with Natural England to help solve the spiralling issue of deer overpopulation in the UK. We have built out our very own venison supply chain, from stalker to carcass prep to butcher all under one operation, to ensure traceability.

The Deer

There are 6 species of deer found in the UK. Red Deer (a.350,000), Roe Deer (a.800,000), Fallow Deer (a.200,000), Muntjac (a.150,00), Sika Deer (a.35,000), Chinese Water Deer (a.10,000).



Only Red and Roe are endemic to the UK, Fallow were brought over by the Romans and the last three were introduced to estates more recently as novelties before escaping and breeding prolifically. They have no natural predators.



Issues

Deer **thrive** in the UK with no natural predators and the ability to travel freely through food rich farmland. The natural habitat of these deer is woodland from which they gain shelter and food. Although they will eat grass in a pinch like cows and sheep, the buds, shoot and leaves of young trees and shrubs are far more nutritious and thus favourable to the deer.

Over-browsing of forests by deer creates 'locked forests' in which mature trees continue to grow but their young replacements are unable to gain a foothold, creating the forest equivalent of an aging population! Deer will also remove the shrub layer in the forest, impacting habitat for other key endemic species.

Deer carry **bovine tuberculosis** (TB), that can spread to cows via shared water troughs. Once a herd of cows is found with TB, it must be destroyed to prevent further spread of the disease, devastating farmers livelihoods. Overpopulation of deer increases the likelihood of this occurring.

The AA estimates **700 people** per year are injured in road accidents involving deer. This number will increase with population.

Compared to a beef baseline of **30 kg CO₂e/kg** our venison has an average of 50% lower carbon emission. This is mainly due to the elimination of winter feed necessities in the wild product.

Nutrition

Wild venison is **high in protein and low in fat**. It contains about 1/3rd the fat of beef and much less saturated fat. It is excellent for muscle maintenance, recovery, and low-fat diets. It is also much higher than any farmed meats in **iron** (blood) and **vitamin B12** (energy). The wild diet also provides high **omega-3** (regeneration) levels and ensures **no hormones and antibiotics** at all are present in the meat, as is common with farmed animals.

Nutritional Profile of Wild Venison (per 100g, cooked, lean)

(Values from UK food composition tables, British Deer Society, NHS resources)

Nutrient	Wild Venison	Beef (lean)	Chicken (skinless)	Lamb (lean)
Calories	~120 kcal	~190 kcal	~165 kcal	~205 kcal
Protein	~24 g	~20 g	~24 g	~20 g
Fat (total)	~2-3 g	~10 g	~3.6 g	~12 g
• Saturated fat	~1 g	~4 g	~1 g	~5 g
Iron	~4 mg (25-30% RDA)	~2.6 mg	~1.3 mg	~2 mg
Vitamin B12	~2-3 µg (100%+ RDA)	~2.5 µg	~0.3 µg	~2.6 µg
Zinc	~3-4 mg	~5 mg	~1 mg	~4 mg
Omega-3 fats	~50-100 mg	~40 mg	~50 mg	~120 mg
Cholesterol	~70 mg	~75 mg	~70 mg	~78 mg